

UTT Chapter 09 Assignment

Hello!

Finals are quickly approaching, so I am spending most of my time in the library. Nothing has changed too much since I last wrote except for my coffee consumption. Let's just say if I were to bleed, I'm pretty sure I would bleed espresso. Honestly though, I'm not too worried about most of my finals, but Art History has a really long paper due in a few days. Paige and I are going to meet up tomorrow so she can help me put together a decent paper. She is the one really interested in postmodern art.

In other news, I went back home this weekend to visit my family. It was awesome eating homemade food instead of the dining hall chow I am usually subject to. Nothing beats Mom's homemade lemon meringue pie. It also gave me a chance to catch up on sleep. I hadn't realized how tired I was. Now I am all rested, armed with several dozen chocolate chip cookies, ready to take on finals next week.

While at home, I registered for a philosophy class with Sarah and Mark for next semester. We checked out some of the required texts, and it looks like I have a lot of difficult reading ahead of me! At book club yesterday, we already started discussing some of the concepts we will cover in class. Have you ever heard of some of these terms: *metaphysics*, *epistemology*, *ontology*, and *epiphenomenalism*? I had no idea that philosophy would be so complicated.

I also didn't realize that philosophy could be so divisive. My friends at book club all had different opinions over the subject. Sarah said the only way to know anything is by the scientific method. She argued that nothing about the immaterial or supernatural could be known since it was outside the realm of scientific inquiry. Mark seemed to agree until Sarah said there is no inherent purpose in the world. Mark responded that history does have a purpose, and the world is gradually progressing toward economic equality. Nathan piped up saying we there is purpose, but took issue with the idea that matter is all there is. Paige declared the whole conversation pointless since we are all constrained by our own experiences. All the while, I am sitting there just trying to follow what everyone was saying.

After a while, though, I had to go study. I left more confused than when I arrived. Maybe you can help me! Sarah and Mark appear to agree on a lot, but they obviously have some different thoughts on philosophy. **How do Marxism and Secularism differ in their views on philosophy?** Paige didn't really talk about what she thought. **What is the philosophical position of Postmodernism?** As usual, Mark has some strange things to say. **What are the philosophical views of New Spirituality?** After these conversations, I am confused about what I am supposed to think as a Christian about philosophy. **What does Christianity have to say about philosophy?**

I really appreciate your help! You rock!

Later!

-Doug

Doug brought up four different questions; below is a rough outline of possible responses:

1. How do Marxism and Secularism differ in their views on philosophy?

Both Marxism and Secularism agree that the material world is all that exists; therefore, both hold to **materialism**. Consequently, they both deny the supernatural and believe that all phenomena can be explained in terms of natural causes, an idea called **naturalism**. Where they part ways is in Marxism's belief in the dialectic. Marxism goes beyond mere materialism by asserting that the dialectic is able to guide the material world toward a state of perfection. According to **dialectic materialism**, society is ultimately progressing through a series of class struggles towards a future economic utopia. The cyclical clashes between the thesis and antithesis will continual indefinitely, until the struggle is inevitable resolved with the final synthesis of communism. [9.2a, 9.3b]

2. What is the philosophical position of Postmodernism?

Postmodernism rejects the correspondence theory of truth, the belief that a proposition is true if it corresponds to reality. According to Postmodernism, truth is in the eye of the beholder and not something that can be objectively known. What we call "truth" is just our subjective interpretation of reality, not reality itself. This idea is call **anti-realism**, the belief that objective reality doesn't exist (or that if it does exist, no one has unmediated access to it). The postmodern view of metaphysics is that our words don't describe reality as it truly is; rather, our words just describe our interpretations of reality. What we assume is ultimately real is actually just the reality we construct in our minds based upon our own unique culture, language, and experience. Likewise, what we assume to know is also just a social construction. Knowledge isn't justified true belief; it is basically community consensus. Since we don't have objective access to the real world, knowledge about reality is reduced to agreement. [9.4b]

3. What are the philosophical views of New Spirituality?

New Spirituality's immaterialism is virtually the opposite philosophy held as that held by materialistic worldviews like Secularism and Marxism. New Spiritualists hold to **spiritual monism**—the belief that reality is ultimately divine. Consequently, they downplay the relevance of the physical world in order to concentrate on spiritual existence. New Spiritualists contend that knowledge of ultimate reality can only be truly found in consciousness. If we want to know about the world, then we must transcend the physical and tap into the divine essence of the cosmos. For New Spiritualists, truth is known primarily through feeling and experience, not through scientific experimentation. Since all is one, the point is not understanding reality but *experiencing* it and reuniting with it. [9.5]

4. What does Christianity have to say about philosophy? [9.7]

Christianity rejects both materialism and spiritual monism; instead it adheres to metaphysical **dualism**—the belief that reality is ultimately composed of two essential substances: the material (nature explained in chemical and biological terms) and the immaterial (nature that interacts with but also transcends the material world). Historically, Christianity has been very concerned with the life of the mind and the pursuit of knowledge. According to Luke 10:27, we are to love God with our hearts as well as with our minds. Christianity does not require blind faith; rather, Christianity encourages careful thinking in the pursuit of truth and knowledge. It is a philosophical stance that is reasonable, rational, and defensible.